

3.1 Power Potential



Power Supplies

A behind-the-scenes player. For us, pressing the power button to turn on the PC is a simple matter—we couldn't care less about what the power supply does in order to power the computer. But when you are upgrading your machine, you need to pay attention to these details.

The more components you put inside the computer, the more power it will require. If the power supply is not up to the task, it could get fried. Also, it could cause your computer to shut down unexpectedly and repeatedly. To avoid this, you need to calculate your power supply needs before you buy one. But before we get into that, let's look at the various types of power supplies available.

AT Power Supply

This type of power supply came with older machines such as Pentium and Pentium 3 machines, and was out of the scene with the exit of the Pentium 3 generation, making way for the newer and more powerful ATX type. AT power supplies were cheap, provided a decent amount of power, and withstood some amount of electrical problems such as brown-outs and over-voltage. But some people haven't been that lucky. It's advisable to opt for an ATX power supply when you are upgrading.

ATX Power Supply

These power supplies were available several years ago, but were not prevalent in older systems. Newer systems with Pentium 4 processors needed an ATX type of power supply as a requirement. Although more of a forced upgrade, it's better since when you ultimately migrate to PCIe express, you'll need an ATX power supply.